

THE LAST CUT

by

Original Screenplay

Written for Production / Media Use

1 INT. EDIT SUITE - NIGHT

A dark editing room. Three monitors glow against the silence. On the center screen, a paused frame shows a crowded railway platform. The timecode reads 02:13:47:08.

MAYA, 28, an assistant editor with tired eyes and a coffee gone cold, scrubs backward through the footage.

MAYA

Come on. Where are you?

She stops. Plays three seconds. Stops again.

On screen: a REPORTER interviews commuters. Behind him, almost hidden by the crowd, a YOUNG MAN looks directly into the camera.

Maya leans closer.

MAYA

That's not possible.

She opens another clip from the same shoot. Different angle. Different time.

The same young man is there.

Maya reaches for her phone and calls someone.

MAYA

Arjun, wake up. I need you
at the studio.

INTERCUT WITH:

2 INT. ARJUN'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

ARJUN, 32, cinematographer, answers from a dark bedroom.

ARJUN

Maya, it's two in the morning.

MAYA

3 INT. EDIT SUITE - LATER

The door swings open. Arjun enters carrying his camera bag.

ARJUN

Show me.

Maya places four clips side by side.

CAMERA A - 6:42 P.M.

CAMERA B - 7:10 P.M.

PHONE FOOTAGE - 7:26 P.M.

B-ROLL CAMERA - 8:03 P.M.

In every frame, the same young man appears somewhere in the background. Same gray shirt. Same expression. Eyes toward lens.

ARJUN

Maybe he followed the crew.

MAYA

Watch this one.

She plays the B-roll camera clip.

The frame shows an empty platform before the public arrived.
The young man stands alone at the far end.

ARJUN

Who shot this?

MAYA

You did.

Arjun studies the screen.

ARJUN

I don't remember him.

Maya enlarges the image. Compression breaks around the man's face, but his eyes remain strangely clear.

MAYA

Neither do I.

A faint SOUND leaks from the speakers.

VOICE (ON FOOTAGE)

...don't cut...

They freeze.

ARJUN

Play that again.

4 INT. EDIT SUITE - CONTINUOUS

Arjun checks the audio tracks.

ARJUN
There was no microphone near
him.

MAYA
There wasn't supposed to be
anyone near him.

She isolates the channel and raises the gain.

VOICE (ON FOOTAGE)
You already used my story.

Maya looks at Arjun.

MAYA
What does that mean?

Arjun searches the production drive.

Folders scroll past: NEWS_ARCHIVE, CITY_FIRE, ELECTION_DAY,
FLOOD_RESCUE, MISSING_PERSONS.

He stops at an old folder.

MISSING_PERSONS_2019.

Inside is a thumbnail of the same young man.

ARJUN
I remember this shoot.

Maya opens the file.

ON SCREEN - an old interview with a mother holding a photograph.

MOTHER (ON FOOTAGE)
His name is Kiran. Twenty-two.
He left for work and never came
home.

The photograph is the young man from the station footage.

MAYA
Did they find him?

Arjun doesn't answer.

He opens the final broadcast package.

The mother's interview lasts three seconds.

5 INT. EDIT SUITE - PRE-DAWN

The monitors flicker.

Every open clip changes at once.

Kiran is no longer in the background.

Now he stands in the FOREGROUND, filling each frame.

KIRAN (ON SCREEN)
Finish the story.

Arjun steps back.

ARJUN
Maya...

The center monitor switches to a black screen.

A new folder appears on the desktop:

KIRAN_FINAL

Maya opens it.

Inside: dozens of videos, police documents, voice notes, photographs, and one location pin.

MAYA
This wasn't on our drive.

ARJUN
Disconnect the network.

MAYA
No.

She opens a voice note.

KIRAN (V.O.)
If anyone finds this, I didn't
disappear. I saw something I
wasn't supposed to see.

Arjun and Maya exchange a look.

KIRAN (V.O.) (CONT'D)
The camera was still running.

Maya opens the final video.

A shaky night recording begins.

We do not see what is ahead. We only see Kiran's terrified face

6 INT. EDIT SUITE - DAWN

Morning light begins to enter through the blinds.

Maya creates a new project.

TITLE: KIRAN - UNCUT

ARJUN
If this is real, we can't just
publish it.

MAYA
Then we verify everything.

She imports the files.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Dates. Metadata. Police records.
Every frame.

Arjun slowly pulls up a chair.

ARJUN
And if someone at the station
knew?

MAYA
Then we find out who.

The footage begins copying into the project.

1% ... 12% ... 38% ...

On another monitor, the old 2019 broadcast plays silently.
Kiran's mother's face appears again.

Maya restores the full interview to the timeline.

MOTHER (ON FOOTAGE)
Please don't let people forget
him.

Maya stops.

MAYA
We won't.

The copy reaches 100%.

For one second, Kiran appears again on the center monitor.

This time, he is not looking into the camera.

He turns away and walks into the morning crowd.